in the Indian setting, with a deep understanding of the surrounding conditions. We only change one piece of policy at a time, while everything else stays unchanged. We have to find the best given the constraints of the environment.

Ground-up design of solutions, from first principles, for the Indian environment will often look different from those seen elsewhere.

The institutions of the First World carry enormous prestige. The sum total of these institutional designs adds up to modernity and prosperity. However, when one element at a time is sought to be transplanted into India, we run the risk of being the sorcerer's apprentice (who uses the spell without knowing why it works) and engaging in isomorphic mimicry (copying the form without copying the function).

Public policy thinking in India requires metis: deep experiential local knowledge. Level-1 thinking is coming up with nutty proposals. Level-2 thinking is copying from websites. Level-3 thinking is grounded in metis, in thinking from the first principles.

There are some situations where it is possible for policy thinking in India to free-ride on state capacity outside India. When this can be done, this is welcome, as it reduces the requirements of building state capacity in India.